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Eric Alexander

Tenor saxophonist Eric Alexander has recorded prolifically since his debut in 1991. He is a graduate of the jazz program at William Paterson University and he cites George Coleman and Harold Mabern as important influences on his approach to jazz improvising.

Eric was interviewed at Hamilton College on March 31, 2010, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are interviewing for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, on campus, with Eric Alexander. Welcome.

EA: Thank you for having me.

MR: I have a little scenario I was going to start off with. Let's suppose my son or daughter is about 19, which has now passed, but they are an avid jazz musician, quite passionate, and they're looking at a career in jazz, and I say to them, "That's an awful tough life with not much security," etc. etc. And they answer to me, "Yeah, but look at Eric Alexander." Is that a —

EA: A valid response?

MR: A valid response to my parental concern?

EA: Well if they knew a lot about me it might be semi-valid because, you know, if they were to say look, Eric Alexander, when he was 18 or 19 years old, knew about two tunes by heart, couldn't improvise through a jazz blues effectively, didn't know the changes to that, and he told his parents the same thing and they said you're crazy, you know, stick a fork in that idea. But he figured out how to play in a very short period of time and ended up having a relatively successful career. You know if they knew all that information I would say well it's actually not such a bad answer. I think if I were a parent, and I wasn't who I am but I had some understanding of the situation, I think what I would tell my kids is there's no time like the present. If you really want to give this a shot, do it while you're young. You know, devote five or six years of your life to pursuing this dream as best you can with every ounce of effort you have and every bit of love you have for the music. See where that takes you. If you get to a point where it becomes painfully, for sure, but painfully apparent that you just aren't going to be able to do it, you'll have time to turn around and do something else. But don't let a really deep-seated love for the music fester inside your body until you are a middle-aged person and then suddenly freak out and tell your wife or husband oh my God I've been living a lie my whole life, I have to pursue my dream of jazz. I'm quitting my job and I'll try to support the kids as best I can. I mean I've seen that happen to people. And I think that's really a far scarier scenario than a late-

teen person, you know, with a certain amount of musical talent thinking, yeah I want to give this a try. I think it's okay to try things when you're young, because you have time to recover.

MR: So you weren't one of those junior high students who would blow people away at the local jazz festival.

EA: I'm not going to lie about that. I was certainly a musical standout, but compared to what. I mean in a small town in Washington State where nobody my age knew how to improvise at all, really to speak of. You know the fact that I knew how to play a blues scale and do something semi-convincingly, you know it sounded very appealing to the adults and the music teachers who heard me do it. But the reality is, compared to the other people in my age bracket that had been serious about playing music, you know, in other parts of the country, and had really listened to the right things and practiced the right things. You know if you were to stack me up against them at that point you'd say well this guy has absolutely no chance, if you were to take it at face value at that point, you'd say he's in a completely different ballpark. But that having been said, and like I said before, I mean I firmly believe that everyone sort of has their time, their really fruitful period where the music kind of chooses them as opposed to someone saying oh, I want to be a jazz musician. Something happens, they hear something, they have a certain experience, and it's almost like the music takes them over and if you really use that moment in your life effectively and like I said, do the right things and follow that path, then you can make up for so much — whatever you want to call it — lost time or time that you didn't do the right thing. You can catch up quickly.

MR: What was your moment?

EA: I didn't really have a specific moment, but what I can tell you is I'm wearing this shirt today interestingly enough. I went to Indiana University right out of high school. And I wasn't even sure I wanted to play music but I was involved in the jazz program there as part of an overall liberal arts degree. Within the first week of arriving there, I heard people in the practice rooms at the music school doing things I couldn't believe. You know I hadn't heard people do that before. And my first thought was oh my God, I'll never be able to do that. But that thought was shortly followed by I'm going to figure that out and do it better than them. You know, sort of like a competitive impulse. And then of course I met other students there who had record collections. They had all these things that I had never heard. So they're playing this music that, it's really like I'd been waiting my whole life to hear this music and never had a chance to really hear it. So when suddenly you're given these kinds of experiences or you have these kinds of experiences, I mean if you're ready for it it's kind of like a dormant volcano inside you that just really takes you over.

MR: You had mentioned yesterday your father listening to you practice, and can't you play a song all the way through or something. Did you win them over, your parents, with your dedication?

EA: I don't think my parents really ever knew until later how dedicated I was. Because I think the proof is really in the pudding. And I wasn't living with them. I was far away from home when this started to happen to me. You know I had periods of time in high school where I would prepare very diligently for a saxophone recital, classical saxophone, I would learn a piece and make big strides and have some effective practice moments. So they knew I was talented. You know all of the teachers would tell them, oh your son's very talented. And my parents are musical as well so they could hear it. But I don't think they — I don't know what they thought. I'm sure they were a little bit uneasy about, not when I went to Indiana University, they were fine with that. It was at the end of that first year when I said I'm going to New York, I'm leaving Indiana. I want to go right to where everything is happening. I might not even go to school, Dad. I might just go try to figure out how to play in Greenwich Village. And another one of his classic lines, he said, "If you do that, kid, you'll be selling your ass within a week." So I think at that point they sort of rallied. You know my parents are divorced but they joined forces and said, "Look, you're not dropping out of school. If you want to go to the New York area you better find someplace where you can get a degree and at least be somewhere safe while you're pursuing this cockamamie idea." So I found William Paterson — a friend of mine and I found William Paterson college. I don't even know how we found it. It's really serendipitous. I don't know how these things fall into place, but it was sort of a last ditch, it was the last place we could possibly apply to in the late part of the spring semester. And we sent audition tapes and Rufus Reid who was the head of the department heard our audition tapes and, for whatever reason, even though they weren't very good, said yeah, these guys have some talent, I'm letting them in, they really want this. We were begging and pleading. And the next semester I get to William Paterson and the first instructor I had in the small group ensemble was Harold Mabern. And really the rest is history.

MR: He must have recognized something in you.

EA: He claims he does. I don't say this to try to be funny or make the story more interesting, I can't figure out what he saw in me.

MR: You know there's a little thing on, I'm not sure whose website it is, if it's yours or his, it's somewhere, a little thing about you playing a ballad. He told you to play a ballad, it might have been "Embraceable You."

EA: He taught me "Embraceable You."

MR: Yeah. And he must have, I have to think that he heard something that made him feel like okay this student is worth my while.

EA: Well I can only speculate. I'll tell you I was very scared, but so ignorant was I, I didn't know who Harold Mabern was. I mean I could tell that he was somebody super important, but I didn't know who he was. And I had spent that summer switching from alto saxophone to tenor, and I had just gotten an old Otto Link mouthpiece, which is what I've been playing since then, and had to figure out how to play it, and I'd been listening to some Coltrane records kind of trying to approximate that sound. So maybe when I played the melody, so nervous and disoriented was I that I was really taking my time and not overblowing and maybe some little bits of that influence were coming out. It almost could sound like I was patient as opposed to terrified. Maybe that's what he heard. Well I just had patience. Yeah, there's a little bit of Coltrane in that sound. You know, and then maybe I was able to get off one or two little melodic ideas that were reminiscent of something. But I do remember him asking me, right after that, he said, "Young man, who are your favorite tenor players?" And I only knew about six. So I said "Coltrane," and then, for number two, and I didn't say it necessarily because it was true, it was the first name that came to my mind, I said "George Coleman," and then I said "Sonny Rollins." And for him, and see that's luck again, that's the perfect answer for him, because he puts Coltrane number one but George Coleman number two and the great Sonny Rollins, of course, everyone loves him, he puts him number three. But unlike most people who put Sonny Rollins and Trane neck and neck, Harold and people that are close to George and love George always put him right after Trane.

MR: And a lot of people, George Coleman is not on a lot of people's lists.

EA: He's off the radar.

MR: And was that because of your compatriots in Indiana?

EA: That I mentioned George Coleman? You know I swear I really don't know why. I think maybe in a *DownBeat* magazine. You know of course I had heard him on a recording. I used to listen to "Maiden Voyage" so he is one of the tenor players that I knew of. But I remember there was an ad in *DownBeat* magazine for these plastic reeds, which I don't think he ever used, but he was one of the endorsers. I and just remember his signature. His signature is very clean, like the way he plays. You know he doesn't make a big hoop and slop at the end. He takes his time. It's like Joe DiMaggio's signature or something. So that signature was kind of in my mind too. I just said "George Coleman."

MR: That's neat how that stuff happens.

EA: But then, Monk, the truth is that did become my order of my top three.

MR: And he sent you to George Coleman, right?

EA: Well he told me to go see him. I never went to see him. I saw George play live and I was so scared of that man I didn't want to be within five feet of him. I didn't go actually see him until, if I'm not mistaken, it may have been after my senior year or maybe after my junior year, but it wasn't right away.

MR: What was scary about him?

EA: Well you know, if you don't know him, he's first of all he's physically imposing. He looks like an NFL linebacker. And musically he's very imposing. He plays the keys off the saxophone and he's doing things that you can't imagine ever being able to do if you're a young player sitting there listening to him. How is he switching keys? How is he playing so fast? How does he play ballads like that? You know, everything. It's like I said yesterday, it's like standing at the base of Mount Everest and looking up. It's scary. I didn't want to get too close to that.

MR: So your degree was in jazz performance?

EA: I guess that's what it's called. I haven't even looked at my diploma to be honest. I mean I graduated with really good marks.

MR: But you didn't get, like some parents would say okay, do the music thing but at least get a teaching degree to fall back on.

EA: No.

MR: Okay. You don't have the fall back on.

EA: No. And I'm not saying that's a bad thing. And I suppose I shouldn't use myself necessarily as a reference for everyone. But I just really believe that there are many people who share a similar level of talent. You know Harold [Mabern] was talking yesterday about 97 percent perspiration, 3 percent inspiration? I believe there are many, many people that are gifted, at least to a certain level. You know we're not all Mozart or Charlie Parker. But there are many people with a certain level of musical talent, a gift if you will, and it's really just those that do the right things and stay on a very consistent path, make the right choices. There are a lot of things that come into play. Who do you meet on the way up? If I hadn't met the people on the way up that I met, what would have happened to me? It's very interesting. But that is why I say if you have a certain level of talent and you really want to spend those years pursuing it, that's the time.

MR: The Thelonious Monk competition, when you came in second place one year I guess, did that do anything for you ostensibly? Open any doors for you or —

EA: It made it so that people who had never heard of me before had now heard of me. So I guess that did something for me. I think I got one gig directly related to that. So in terms of work, not really. And I don't think it got me any record deals or anything like that. There were no record companies climbing around me. They're all climbing around number one. Number two and the rest were out pretty much, we're on our own. But we

all, not me so much, but many of the other guys already had been working with people. They were already pretty high profile professional guys. I think the prerequisite, or one of the prerequisites to be in the competition was that you did not have a leader recording released on a major label. But there was no prerequisite, you know, you can't have worked with a jazz legend. Because these guys certainly had. I mean I know, among others, I know Chris Potter was working with Red Rodney at that time. And some of the guys, Todd Williams and some of the other saxophonists had been working with Wynton. And I know Joshua had already played at the Village Vanguard and played with his father and probably Ed Blackwell and a number of different people. So he'd had some good experience too. And I was just starting to get some experience at that point with Charles Earland out of Chicago. Okay so to go back to the question I think the biggest thing it probably gave me was more hope. It made me realize, okay, I'm right there. And I can get better too. I heard things that some of the other players were doing and I said to myself why didn't I do that? If I had just done that. I know what that is. I can play like that. I don't have to be — I was a real anachronism style player at that point. I played just like Dexter Gordon, which was very appealing to some people. There wasn't enough Eric Alexander in there.

MR: How the heck do you make a living after you graduate from college and you're out pursuing a career in jazz? How did you manage that?

EA: You try as hard as you can to get any sort of gig where you're using your instrument to make money. And if you don't get enough gigs to support yourself, to pay your rent and buy your food and buy whatever else you need to survive, then you get another job outside the music business. I used to be so disappointed that I didn't have what we call jobbing gigs. A lot of my friends did —

MR: Like club dates, and weddings?

EA: Club dates, weddings, private parties. I tried to break into that scene and I was really unsuccessful. I'm not sure why. I would go to these auditions and just bottom out. I never got those gigs.

MR: Can I ask a question there? You auditioned for club dates and weddings?

EA: In New York it's pretty cut throat, Chicago too. You have to go to these agencies that contract all the work. And they say, "Okay kid, do you know 'Hava Nagila?'" And you say okay and you try and play it. And then they name 25 other Jewish melodies that you're supposed to know. No I didn't know any. And then they say well okay, what about they start naming pop/rock tunes and things like that and you're supposed to know the background parts to these things.

MR: I have not heard this anecdote. Are you playing with anybody at that point or are you just standing by yourself?

EA: I was just by myself. You know if a contractor, if somebody calls you and says we have a wedding gig, it's in Southampton, you've got to get there by 6, you know these things pay good. You're going to be in a horn section with trumpet, trombone and you know the rhythm section and two vocalists. You have to show up out there and these guys really do put the thing together. Some of the wedding bands were, and are, consistent units that always move around together. But very often they throw people together. It's kind of like a jazz gig and you have to know all these background parts and things that you're supposed to be able to do like that. I didn't know any of it. It's pretty tricky too, to get the knowledge without having had the experience in order to acquire it, unless you went out on the gig and had to hear all these background parts and fumble through it a few times, I don't know how else you get it. It still kind of vexes me. Maybe there are some books you can get to study it or someone can prep you.

MR: I think it comes more from your listening habits. If you listen to Motown a lot or that kind of music. But again, you do then need to get thrown into a situation where you can try it.

EA: So anyway, well for whatever reason I just never got those gigs. So it was either playing on the street with my friends in New York, there were one or two clubs in New York where we had little pass the hat gigs for a week, and then it was telemarketing during the day, for me, things like that. I remember for about six months selling surgical gloves over the phone. That was my job. I'd get there, nine to five, sell surgical gloves. And then go home and practice for four hours and just be exhausted. And then get up and do it again. But one of the things was when I went to New York, see because after I graduated from William Paterson I went to Chicago for two years. And there I was making a living playing music exclusively. My cost of living was really low and I got to the point where I had five or six nights of work a week with organ trios and singers on the south side. So after two years I said all right I'm going to go to New York now, let's make this final step. This is even after the Thelonious Monk thing. So imagine that, I mean after I came in second in the Thelonious Monk competition, and you asked me what did it do for you, I'm selling surgical gloves, you know, telemarketing. This is like a year and a half after that competition. And this is even when I've started to make some recordings too. I just had this idea in my mind, all right if I can't get to a reasonable standard of living and lifestyle playing music by the time I'm 25 I'll quit. And I don't know if that was true or not, I mean I never had to find out.

MR: Oh well that's good. Most people would accept that. They'd say okay, you're going to give it two more years.

EA: I don't think I would have quit.

MR: I can't imagine that, because you seem to have the passion and the drive to keep going, which sort of begs the questions, at what level do you ever say, okay, this is where I wanted to be? Are you there now or do you just like not have a specific level in mind?

EA: Well I think it's less specific than that. It's almost — well first of all I can say that I'm more comfortable with my playing than I've ever been. You know, I feel better about it. That's the first part of it. But second, I'm not satisfied either. And it really comes down to, you know, gig to gig. You know sometimes I'll go out on a gig and I'll feel great and feel like I can do anything that I wanted to do. And I'll have to say well it's never so good it couldn't get better, and then the next gig you go out and you don't feel good, you feel like you played really poorly and you say well it's not so bad, it couldn't be worse. You have to have a real even keel about how you react to how you're doing because some days are great but there are going to be just as many days that aren't so great. And you can't beat yourself up, but you also can't get cocky if you're doing well. You know you just have to stay focused and it's kind of philosophical. You have an ideal in your mind of what would be perfect and you just keep moving towards it, but that ideal morphs and changes over the years too so you'll never get there. It's like chasing a rainbow.

MR: I sometimes wonder if you watch basketball players for instance, and they have this tremendous night, everything's falling and they're in the right place at the right time and I wonder if they think why can't I do that every night?

EA: I'm sure they do. But I think, you know, (a) through experience they know that they can't, and (b) they realize that often times the truth is you want your worst to be good enough, or your average to be better than most. If you're great, okay it's going to be great. And anybody — every dog has his day — everyone can have a great day. But you want to get to the point where your average performance is pretty damn good I guess. Consistency is important.

MR: That's a good way to put it. What's it like, you have a family, but much of your work is not within 50 miles of your home.

EA: What is that like? Well it's definitely hard on me but it's certainly harder on my wife. I think the kids are okay. They've known that scenario their entire lives. That's what they know. They know dad's in and out. We have a great family and my wife is tough as nails. If it weren't for her none of this would be possible that's for sure, because she's a full time professor and half-time single mom, really. Half the time she has my help but half the time she doesn't. So she's got a lot on the table.

MR: What does she teach?

EA: She's a professor of Spanish at Fordham.

MR: Interesting. Does she like the music that you play?

EA: She likes it a lot. She's not, I mean she'll tell you she's not a music expert, she's not even particularly musical. She doesn't sing or play an instrument. She doesn't know anything about music in terms of the nut and bolts of how things work. But I mean I guess being around me and all the great musicians that she has had the chance to meet through me and she's had the chance to hear them play, I think she has a very good appreciation, she has a great appreciation but she also has discerning taste now. She knows when things are jive and when they're happening. She can really tell. So that's lucky because I feel fortunate about that. I have some friends whose wives really dislike what they do for a living, dislike the whole jazz scene and the kind of people that are there and don't even really like the music. That's got to be really hard. I can't imagine that.

MR: So if you have a — I know you do some teaching at Purchase and the students you saw yesterday here, if they said to you how do I get into the scene, like you, are there any specific things you can say to them except don't take my gig?

EA: I mean you know I'd have to go individual by individual. I'd have to spend a little time with them and see where they are and see how they progress after a few weeks of doing some things that I ask them to do. But you have to have a certain repertoire internalized. You know, jazz musicians have to know hundreds of tunes and I think most of these young people know very few so it's a huge problem. I'd have to spend a ton of time memorizing the jazz repertoire, which means American popular standards that jazz musicians favor and jazz originals that have become classics that everyone knows. You just start with that and you're talking hundreds of tunes. But it's the kind of stuff they have to know if they're going to walk into a jam session in New York City, take their horn out and whoever's on stage starts playing "Along Came Betty," just for instance, that's a jazz original that everyone has to know. There's no choice about it. You can't say oh well I wanted to play but I don't know that tune so I'll put my horn back in the case. That's a big strike. People notice that kind of stuff. Or even worse, let me pull out my *Real Book*. Nobody wants to see that.

MR: Thank you for saying that.

EA: Yeah. So I would say learning tunes is hugely important. And it's just better for your musicianship in general. And I think all of them, based on what I heard yesterday, need to absorb, I mean some jazz language but a ton more than they have. You can't talk to other jazz musicians unless you know the language. I mean that sounds very simplistic but it's absolutely true. You can't just play some kind of grouping of notes that doesn't swing and doesn't have the right kind of effect in terms of the way you're presenting your sound and your articulation. There are certain ways jazz musicians do things. That's not say there's one way, there are many ways within this big room. But you have to be in there. You have to have a connection to the history of the music. And I just don't think they've

done enough serious listening. They haven't immersed themselves in the river, in that big continuum that is at the end and the beginning at the same time. You've got to jump in there and float for a couple of years and suck up the past, present and future of the music. And then you can start to kind of swim around in there and do something. But otherwise you're just flailing and you're going to drown. You have no place being there until you kind of soak it up.

MR: Do you give your students a list of must-know songs?

EA: I don't but I should. One of the reasons I don't is that there are, to be sure there are tunes and I don't know that I should know. But what I do insist on is that they keep a tune list and that they try to learn, and they don't do it very well. I'm really pissed off at them. I tell them every week, "Two tunes. I want two tunes this week and you have to be able to play these tunes with flare and confidence. There's no rhythm section, here take out your horn and play that tune. I don't care if you make a mistake here and there but I want the time to be strong from beginning to end and if you flub a note, who cares, recover and keep going because that's what you're going to have to do when you're playing anyway." They have to be able to do that and they have to be able to improvise on their own. They have to be the piano, bass, drums and saxophone by themselves. And if you can do that, okay I'll give it to you, you know the tune. Put it on your list, and review your list every day. If you're getting foggy on something touch it up. It's a little disappointing to me because I feel like the formula is actually incredibly simple I suppose, but actually sticking to it and following it is difficult because people just can't do it. It's not learning algebra. It's like five things: work on your sound, learn tunes, learn vocabulary, practice things through the keys, I don't even know what the other thing would be, play with people. Get people together and try all these concepts out. It's like five things, just do it every day of your life for the next five years and see where you are. You know?

MR: That's a tall order for most young musicians I think.

EA: Yeah well I just think this is a real ADD generation too. I mean I guess my generation was also compared to previous generations. It's really a problem.

MR: I was going to ask, because Harold was talking yesterday about going on the road and the guys had their stacks of LPs. And that was their source and it was heavy and it was work to carry it around. But I'm wondering if the technology and everything at our fingertips is good and bad.

EA: It's definitely bad in some ways. I mean one of the most obvious ways that it's bad that is painfully obvious to me, if I give one kid "Charlie Parker with Strings," and say this is the only thing you're allowed to listen for six months. I want you to learn every note that he plays on at least two or three of these tunes. And then another guy I give a 30 gigabyte iPod and say "have fun." I guarantee the guy with the one record is going to come out

better. He's going to learn more. There's no question. Because playing this music is about knowing, it's not how much you know but it's how well you know what you supposedly know. If you have a little bit of information that you have absolutely mastered, you're going to play better than somebody with kind of a vague understanding of a lot of things. Because in order to be effective as an improviser you have to be able to — it's not like somebody who could pass a test. You know there are people all over the United States, or all over the world for that matter, that could sit down and pass a theory test. Okay what scale do you use over a minor 7 chord. Fine. How do you spell a dominant 13 flat 9. Fine, they can answer all these questions. That doesn't amount to a hill of beans though when you're on the bandstand and, you know, Louis Hayes is playing 300 miles an hour on the drums and Harold is playing piano. You have to hear these things and play something immediately that's going to work. You don't have time to think oh yes, I guess that's a Dorian scale. By the time you thought that, five bars have gone by. You don't even know where you are in the tune. So it's more important to have a small reservoir of information that you really have mastered than a lot of information that you sort of understand a little bit. So that's the problem with the technology, to me. Plus there was something so, you got more of a feeling for the music, when I would hold the records that I would buy. You know I'd wait all week and I'd have fifteen dollars so I'd figure I could get two records. And I'd go buy my two records and just riding back on the subway or whatever, reading the liner notes, I just couldn't wait to get home and put it on and check it out. Plus you have to sit there and listen to it, because you know you're going to have to flip it. And it's too much of a pain to go up and pick the needle and drop it between tracks, so you actually sit and listen to one side of the record. And you flip it over and listen to the second side. And then if there's a particular song that you really like you have to expend a little bit energy to put the needle on that song. It's not like click-click-click, click-click-click. Oh I'm tired of that, spin-spin, another genre. It's just too much information.

MR: I couldn't agree more. What experiences have you had perhaps with Charles Earland or some of the other fellows that you were a sideman with that impacted your eventual role as a leader. Did you learn stuff from those guys musically and otherwise that helped you out?

EA: Well I've been lucky. All the guys that I came up playing with, one of the things they shared is they play music like it's the last time they'll ever play. It's almost like somebody said, "This is the last song you're ever going to play, you better have fun." They give everything they have at all times. I guess it's just that they respect — I mean they're not thinking about it but if you had to give a reason why are they playing it, they just respect and love the music so much. They would never give less than a hundred

percent. I remember playing with Charles Earland in this huge room in Rochester, it was Thanksgiving 1990. Was is ’90 or ’91? Maybe it was ’91. And there were maybe four people in this cavernous room. And he played like a two hour set and almost blew the organ up and was sweating all over the place. What’s he doing? Why is he doing this? Can’t we just go home? But this stuff started to rub off on me. Playing with Harold? I mean if you don’t bring your A game and really step up, he going over, it’s like a tsunami. I mean you’re going to be swept away and be very insignificant very fast. You have to step up and do something. Pat Martino, same kind of thing. These guys play so strong you really have to get in there, and it’s not like you’re fighting with them but if you don’t show that you have some kind of personality and something to add you will be erased quickly. And all these guys have such a tremendous sense of rhythm you know. When I think of all of them, they don’t need a drummer or bass player to create a sense of groove and swing. You know Harold sits down at the piano and he can play by himself. That’s fine. I’ll pay the price of admission for that. You know, I’d play the price of admission just to hear him come. So strong and infectious, his rhythmic style. So those things really rubbed off on my, just passion to play and always try to bring your A game, and have a really strong rhythm, and really play the kind of music that you love. All these guys have figured out over the years what they love to do and they stick to it. There’s a certain thing in this music, you know, go with what you know, go with what you love. Because not everyone can do everything. There’s no point in trying. You really have to within the framework, okay I’m a jazz musician, you have to figure out what standards you really enjoy playing. What kind of tempos do you favor. What kinds of keys do you favor. Major or minor. Things like that.

MR: Is there a scenario if you could imagine, where you got a phone call to do something that could be a significant musical move and that you would turn down?

EA: Yeah. And I have.

MR: And what would that be?

EA: Well I won’t say what that was because I turned it down because I didn’t, I mean I didn’t tell them I can’t do it because I don’t like this music, I said I had prior commitments.

MR: In a general sense could you say what kind of things that you wouldn’t go for?

EA: It’s not so easy because it’s really case by case. In other words, I could never say I won’t take a smooth jazz gig because that’s not true, I might. If somebody called me and said look I’m going to pay you some good money, we want you to come out with this funky smooth jazz band, and Eric, you could just play the way you play. You know, you can kind of do what Miles did. You can put a rock beat behind you but you just play the way you want to play on top of it. I’d do that in a heartbeat. If somebody said I want you to come out and I’m going to pay you a lot of money and you have to really try to play like

Kenny G, we really want you to get deep into that style. I'd probably have to say I can't do that. I don't think I could. No disrespect to him, I just don't think I could do that. I think I would be miserable. I mean maybe okay, three or four days and the money is massive, yeah I could go ahead and give it a shot, but that would be a tough one.

MR: What if someone called and said we're going to do "Ascension?"

EA: Oh I'd love to give that a try, why not, yeah that would be great, I'd love that. Anything that Coltrane every put a stamp on I'd love to give it a try. I don't know if I could do it. You know if some people said we want to just play absolutely free, there's no chord, no rhythm, we don't want to hear one thing that sounds remotely like anything that's ever been heard before. I might have to really think about that. And certain types of big bands. I know this isn't necessarily the best thing to put on the record but I don't necessarily enjoy playing in a big band. I find it really tedious. Probably because I haven't played in good big bands. I only had a few opportunities and some of them weren't necessarily that good of an opportunity. But yeah, it's never been really my cup — I'm more of a small group or medium-sized group guy, that's more my thing.

MR: Do you feel you are a good businessman?

EA: No. Not at all. And my wife reminds me of that every day. I'm not a good businessman. I never ask for enough money. I never fight as hard as I should for things. And I don't demand enough. I'm not a "diva" guy. And it's funny because in this business you see a lot of musicians, because we play the same places so you'll show up in some club and you look at the roster or the line-up that's been there over the course of the last year, so and so, so and so, big named people. And you start to hear the people at the club bitching about how so and so acted, oh they were such a pain, they were demanding this and that, God I couldn't stand it. And this on, oh God it was just awful, what a jerk, the way they treated the staff and they were so demanding and they wanted this and that. And you think what a creep. But then you also think, and I bet they got a hell of a lot more money than I did too. So it almost pays to be a jerk sometimes in this music. But I have a hard time being a jerk.

MR: Yeah. I wonder how many return engagements those jerks get. If they do well at the door, good.

EA: I think look, that's what it is. Cash and money is the bottom line. And sometimes these attitudes become part of, somehow, like bizarre. It's almost battered wife syndrome. People start to like it. They like the fact that these people act like jerks and they come to expect it and it's part of the whole show. It's very strange. It really is. But I guess if you're great enough, look, you can do anything you want. You're going to keep working.

MR: Yeah. That's what annoyed me about the overuse of the word "diva." Like it used to mean something. It used to be backed up with talent.

EA: It said you were great. Right

MR: So okay, you can act like that.

EA: Well and the truth is then it becomes part of the folklore of jazz, talking about how somebody was so great and so mean to everyone that everyone loves to tell their story about how mean so and so was and what they said. You know, it becomes part of the history. So your question was am I a good businessman.

MR: Do you think you're on top of what your record company does with sales and all that?

EA: No. I'm not.

MR: So you have to have a certain amount of trust in people I guess.

EA: Are they going to see this interview?

MR: No.

EA: This is the situation I have with my record company. I ask them for CDs to sell on gigs and I know they're supposed to be charging me for CDs but I never seem to get bills.

MR: You mean the ones that like in other words you have to pay for your own CDs.

EA: I have to buy CDs from the company. It's generally seven dollars a CD or whatever, and they you sell them for fifteen or twenty and you get the profit. I don't really get bills from them for the CDs I've ordered. But then again I don't really get consistent royalty checks that I'm supposed to get for certain types of things, you know, for my compositions, or, we have some agreements about international sales. And it's almost like I kind of let that slide and they let this slide and nobody talks about it. And I'm sure in the end I'm the one that's losing. Because if they were losing they would be talking to me about it. So I should think more clearly about this. But I don't. And other things like my publishing catalogue, I mean I have my works registered and I get royalty checks, but there are other things that I could be doing that I probably need to be doing.

MR: Well some things never change. I mean stories are legend about that kind of thing. It's probably better than it used to be I would think.

EA: Yeah. Well musicians didn't even own their tunes. At least we own our tunes now, most of us. It's not that complicated, you just get some works registration forms from BMI and register your tunes and that's it, you own them.

MR: But your sidemen, the guys you use on your recordings, they get paid once, correct?

EA: Leaders get paid once too. Well I'm sure there are some people with different deals with jazz record companies but that's rare. That's the absolute top level scenario, where you would be getting royalties for sales. It's very rare.

MR: I see. So the royalties you get —

EA: Are mechanicals. For original compositions.

MR: Okay. Well there's a good reason to write.

EA: That's one of the reasons that people like Lee Morgan and Hank Mobley wrote ninety percent of the music on their records, and thank God they were incredible writers. And by contrast this is also one of the problems today, everyone wants their mechanicals and everyone thinks they're a good writer, and most people aren't. So we see records coming out where you look at it and you say, you know what's coming, it's a bunch of stuff that's not really memorable. So I'm kind of torn. And the last few records I've probably stepped too far across the line, I've had less originals than ever. I think I've had one original or two originals on the last couple of records. And the rest of the tunes are sort of out of the way, rarely heard standards, or strange tunes that people wouldn't even expect me to record that we rework. But I know that people like that. I know that the listeners like it and the radio stations like it, and so it serves me well in that respect. I know the CDs sell very well, you know, compared to other CDs that my company puts out. And I know that they always get very good radio play. I mean every CD I've done for High Note Records has made it to number one on the radio play charts.

MR: Nice. And I agree with what you're saying. Like you did the tune "It's Magic," and it's exactly what you're saying when I saw that I go he did "It's Magic"? Like and then I start to sing the song in my head and I go wow, what an interesting choice. I can't wait to hear what you did with that.

EA: Yeah. And I would be the same way too, I mean I often say, okay, let's say I'm at a jazz festival and these guys all come back from the beyond for the greatest jam session ever. You know, it's Coltrane, Sonn — well Sonny Rollins he's here, so Sonny's there and whatever, Johnny Griffin and George Coleman, all these cats, Dexter Gordon. And then the program starts and it's five originals that I've never heard before and I can't even figure out what the chord changes are. Would I enjoy that? No. What do I want to hear them play? Blues, rhythm changes and a couple of standards and see who can be the most creative on that very familiar format, or within that very familiar format. And I think that's one of the things that made, or one of the real joys of being an educated jazz listener. You know historically speaking, knowing material before you hear it. Because then you have a frame of reference. You know you hear a guy do a tune that you've heard a million times before but he does it a little bit differently and then his improvisation has some magical things in it, harmonic substitutions, whatever, and like it's a whole different tune. And it really allows you to appreciate what they're doing even more. Because you're listening from a position of knowledge rather than absolute ignorance. I mean I hear people play sometimes now, and I'm a musician, I'm a professional musician, and I have no idea what's going on. I can't tell what time signature they're in, and I spend most of the time going like one, two, three, you know, figuring out, okay, they're in thirteen. And then by the end of the tune, what is that, that's like a weird, like a

major 7 flat 5, and then it goes down a minor third and it's an inverted strange triad with a strange extension. And by the time I get to the end of the tune I've figured out a few chords and the time signature and I haven't heard one thing that the people have played because I've spent the whole time trying to get my bearings so that I could understand it a little bit. And I don't know how the casual listeners are reacting favorably to it because I can't believe that they could be enjoying it as much as they seem to be.

MR: I think that's what a lot of the veterans, the players that started in the thirties, if you ask them about the younger players, a lot of the comments I got were very similar and that was that all the young people sound the same, and that they, because they're learning the same scales and all this and they're not playing music, they're playing the scales and the patterns and stuff. So I think that is true for them too. Even though that kind of playing might be standard nowadays. I think my question is, is there something that is really hard to teach to students?

EA: There are many things that are really hard to teach. In fact, you can only point them. You can kind of say hey, it's in that box over there. It's not in that box, it's in that box, but you have to go get it out. You can't really, I mean in this music it's a very personal process. So I can say look, do your long tones, if you do things this way you might have some success, listen to these particular recordings and pay close attention. But the work, it's all on them.

MR: And shouldn't it be?

EA: Yeah.

MR: What I'm trying to say is that the people that are going to rise to the top have to have—

EA: It has to come from within them. You can kind of help them open a couple of doors. Yeah but it can be frustrating for students because they think okay I'm studying with this person and I really love their playing, they're going to show me how to play. I'm going to study with this person and I'll learn how to play. We can't do that. We just can't do it. Impossible. They need to lock themselves in a room with two records and practice twelve hours a day and see where they are next year. And it's also hard to work as a teacher week by week. It's not enough time. You know if I sit down for an hour with somebody and give them a few things to work on, they might need a couple of months to get it together to the point where we can move on to the next thing. So what you end up doing is having 13 weeks of lesson plans all 20 percent completed by the end of the semester. And then they have stuff to work on for the next five years. But it's really hard to say okay here's your assignment for this week, and then they come back next week and it's nailed. Okay here's the next thing. And on occasion you get students that are able to do that but the vast majority can't do it.

MR: We were talking about original compositions and I wanted to just play a bit here.

[audio interlude]

MR: That's called "One for Steve," is that right?

EA: Um hum.

MR: Where do you conceive your —

EA: Well that's just a blues with some different chord changes in it.

MR: Um hum. Where does the melody come from, do you sit with your horn and do it? Do you sit at the piano?

EA: On that particular tune I think I sat with my horn and did it. It's pretty much just based on some stuff I heard Coltrane play. You know, getting up to the ninth of a dominant chord and kind of working your way down. I mean it's not verbatim thievery or something he played but it's the concept is similar. And then I put some different chord changes on the turnaround.

MR: And where or when does the decision come, like you decided to have the saxophone and the bass in unison.

EA: We may have just decided that in the studio. You know a lot of times you show up at a recording session with a very skeletal arrangement or idea of what you're going to do, or it's a sketch of a tune and you just kind of throw ideas around the room and everyone just pipes up with their suggestion or their criticism and after a few minutes something clicks and everyone says okay that'll work. But people kind of have to leave their egos at the door to do that. You know you can't come in with this idea this is how I wrote my tune and this is how it's going to be and we're not going to change it. Because if you do that you miss out on a lot of creativity and it's more than a democratic process I don't even know what you'd call it, board room last minute deals. I don't know what it is. But you're not utilizing your musicians to the degree that you could utilize them if you're just going to be a dictator and say this is the way it is. If you trust and really admire the musicians you're working with, you should welcome their input. I mean sometimes you don't like it and sometimes they say things that you say no I don't agree just shut up, that's it. But sometimes, you have to listen to what they say and they may turn you on to an idea that you hadn't thought of. It happens all the time. You know like the last recording we made we were trying to play "It Might As Well Be Spring" and I don't even remember what groove we had on it in the rehearsal, but in the studio all of a sudden Joe Farnsworth, the drummer, said, "You know what about this beat?" and he started playing kind of a rumba or a Latin flavor beat on it. What happens if we play the tune this way? And it was like a boom. All of a sudden the tune made sense. We were kind of dreading doing it. It was just one of those standards that people will think is kind of hip if we do it but we don't really enjoy playing it. We saved it 'till the end of the date. And he came up with this

idea and it made it so easy to play. And it felt like our arrangement, our individual twist on it. So you have to listen to the musicians.

MR: That's great. Do you have, I know it's sort of hard this day and age to have a working band, you know, keep this group together and I'm going to give them enough work to stick with me.

EA: Yeah. Or I guess you can put them on retainer. I mean I can't do that. You know I have my number one guys, my pool of guys that I always want to work with. And I try to get them first. And then if I have to go outside that pool I have another pool that is the second tier or whatever. But it's pretty obvious from my recordings and you see me on gigs, who are the guys I want. If I have a choice I'm calling Harold [Mabern] right away all the time. He can't make everything, so then there are people I move on from there. And it's the same with Joe Farnsworth and John Webber, and those are the first people I call. Because I know we could fly 36 hours to some remote spot in the farthest reaches in the furthest corner of the world and be exhausted and feel like crap and we could go up on stage and we don't have even a talk through. I can just start playing something and they're going to be right there. We can play a whole concert without even discussing one bit of music. So that really gives you a feeling of comfort. You know they have your back. They're ready to play with you, they like your playing, you like their playing, and there's no bullshit. A lot of times when you get up there with musicians that you don't play with on a regular basis there's a lot of feeling out going on, just trying to figure out where so and so is coming from on the bandstand. And that can really detract from the music. Sometimes it's magical and it's fun to listen to, but usually it kind of lowers the level of creativity you can get to.

MR: What do you say to a student, one of those people who is in a constant search, if I only had this horn, if I only had this mouthpiece, if I only could find a good reed?

EA: Welcome to the club. Join the club. We're all there. Well let's start with the mouthpiece and reed, that's your first connection to the sonic world. I mean everything starts right there. If your reed isn't working and your mouthpiece stinks, you're in a world of trouble. I would agree with them if they're upset and their equipment stinks I'd be upset too. You've got to go find something that works. But even when you have things that work, that reed, that can be the difference between a great day and a really bad day. It happens to me all the time. Sometimes I actually want to throw my mouthpiece out the window. Oh, something's wrong with my mouthpiece, I must have dropped it, I must have bumped it, it's not working, my horn is out of adjustment. And all it is is that the reed is no good. You know? So I feel their pain.

MR: Okay.

EA: Finding a reed is hard. Finding a good mouthpiece is hard. The horn, if you have a good horn and it's in good shape, stop blaming the horn. The horn — some students that I've come across have awful horns, I don't know how they can take it. I don't know how they can play with that thing, how then can even get a low note to come out, how they can play in tune. When you're struggling against equipment that doesn't work, that's tough. But if you have something that's decent, that should be good enough. The horn, I always am sure there are people that would disagree with me but a decent horn with a great reed and a great mouthpiece, you're okay.

MR: What do you picture for yourself ten years from now. Do you think that far ahead? Do you have long term sort of projects?

EA: No. I really don't. No my long term projects are more about things that don't have to do with music really. The music is at the top of my list 24 hours a day, but I don't know what my goal is. My goals are very simple. They always involve, I just want to be a better improviser. I want to play better. I want to have a better sound. I want to be able to really impact people immediately when I start playing, the first note out of my horn I want them to say wow, this guy's got it together, okay what's coming next. I mean I want them to really feel some kind of positive and strong message coming from me and my horn. I'm not thinking so much what tunes would I like to do five years from now, what kind of music am I going to get into. I'm not thinking about that at all.

MR: Do you think about — I'm not sure how to phrase this question — but do you imagine what your audience is hearing from you. You're thinking about what you're playing yourself, but do you also think about how are they hearing it.

EA: I actually care a lot about my audience. I think that's part of the reason that I usually feel like I played better in front of people than I do when there aren't people around. To me it's a big part of the equation. People are listening to you, and you are speaking to them. That makes it double important. You know, when I'm playing by myself it's not so important. So I care very deeply about what they think. I mean not bitter, nasty people that just say things to be, I can see through that and I don't care. But whatever sort of fan base I've built up over the years, or educated listeners in certain parts of the world, I mean I want to please them. I want to play music that's on a certain level challenging, I don't want to play down to anybody, but I also want it to be music that they feel good listening to and that they enjoy. I don't want them to be befuddled and sickened by what I'm doing. I want them to be happy to listen to it, and to leave the club feeling better than they felt when they came in. It's really important to me. So yes, I do think about how they are listening.

MR: Well that's a pretty good way to wrap up here I think. Is there anything you want to add that you might say gee I wish I had said something like that in this interview?

EA: Not really. Not off the top of my head. I can't think of anything.

MR: Okay. Well I wish you continued success in your career. I can tell you that you are a name that is in the consciousness of most of these young players, whether or not they're listening to the older fellows or not, they're listening to you, so that's a good thing.

EA: Well in a way it makes me feel good and in a way it's a lot of pressure too. You know, I'd hate to feel that I was misleading a generation of young players, inadvertently.

MR: I don't think so. Well thanks for your time today.

EA: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Okay.